DUHU DEEN KO SAHIB

While the labourers strained and the cattle heaved to put together the chiselled sandstone buildings at Fatehpur, each new quarter was immediately filled with incessant activity and noise. As we have noted, in 1574 Akbar established a translation bureau (maktab khana) in which he gathered together scribes, clerks, translators, theologians, and pundits. A large number of texts, both well known and obscure, were chosen for translation into Persian. These included a number of Sanskrit texts such as the *Rajatarangini* (History of the Kings of Kashmir), and the *Panchatantra*, known in its translation as the *Anwar-i Suhayli*. Arabic encyclopaedias were also translated into Persian as was the *Baburnama*, Babur's memoirs, which he had written in Chaghatai Turki. This was the beginning of Akbar's long-term plan to make Persian the official language of the Mughal Empire and the language which would bind together not only the disparate nobility at court but would also infiltrate into the lower levels of the bureaucracy.

Persian had already arrived in Hindustan with the Ghaznavids, the Ghurids, and then through an influx of writers, poets, and thinkers fleeing Chenghiz Khan's conquest of the Perso–Islamic world. That it was already the language of the Hindustani elite can be gauged from the line of Hafiz of Shiraz when he claimed that 'all the Indian parrots will turn to crunching sugar with this Persian candy which goes to Bengal'. But Persian patronage stagnated for a while in the fifteenth century and the Afghans in the sixteenth century were uninterested in the language too. It was with Humayun that a slow influx of Iranian refugees began which was then greatly encouraged by Akbar. The enormous impetus that Akbar would give to Persian would make it the language of literate Hindustanis from the Indus to the Bay of Bengal, and would bring into the fold of the Mughal Empire people from varied religious and social groups. Extraordinary social mobility was possible for those fluent in Persian as in the case of the qissa-khwan Mir Muhammad Hashim. Hashim began his career as part of the retinue of 'slaves and servants' of Abdur Rahim, and then became a 'panegyrist, storyteller, master of the stables and jagirdar'. It would make